Prime Readiness Map

Six gates stand between a capable shop and a defence buyer's order book. Which of them apply, and how far along the shop is, is what this map sets out — in the order they usually bite, so nothing gets done twice.
November 9, 2026.

Gate	What it is	Where you stand	What it takes	Who owns it
1. Registration	SAM.gov, UEI and CAGE code. Applies: If you sell, or want to sell, to a prime or the government	To be established at discovery: whether the registration is active, and the code it carries	Half a day of someone's time, free. The CAGE code takes about ten business days, and the registration renews every year — a lapse takes you off the books until it is fixed.	You do it; we keep the renewal on the calendar.
2. Cybersecurity	NIST SP 800-171, SPRS, and CMMC as the contract expresses it. Applies: When the work involves controlled data (CUI), or a prime asks	To be established at discovery: where controlled data lives, and what the shop already does about it	Planning bands for a full controlled-data scope, from our own effort table: shop IT 155–365 h; CGP + shop IT 60–140 h; owner 42–95 h; CGP 42–90 h. The scope decides the size of this: a shop handling only federal contract information is looking at fifteen requirements, a shop handling controlled data at a hundred and ten. Your IT provider does the configuration; the records and the evidence are the part with no natural home.	Your IT provider configures; we run the records, the evidence and the calendar.
3. Export control	ITAR registration with the State Department (DDTC). Applies: If you make anything on the munitions list, or handle its drawings	To be established at discovery: whether any part you make or quote is on the munitions list, and whether a registration is on file	Registration, renewed every year, even for a shop that never exports. The real work is naming who owns export compliance, with a backup, and controlling how drawings move. The State Department publishes the fee schedule.	You own the registration; we keep the record and the renewal date.
4. Quality	ISO 9001, AS9100, Nadcap for a special process, first-article records. Applies: If the buyer's supplier quality requirements say so — most aerospace and defence primes do	To be established at discovery: which certificates you hold, what each covers, and when it expires	A certificate cycle runs in months, not weeks, and buyers check the certificate's scope in the registrar's database. Special processes — heat treat, plating, welding, inspection — are accredited one at a time.	A registrar audits; your quality lead runs it; we keep it on the calendar.
5. Purchase order	The clauses that ride in with the order: CUI protection, counterfeit parts, traceability, and specialty metals. Applies: Every defence order, whether or not a prime says so out loud	To be established at discovery: which clauses your current orders carry, and whether melt origin is recorded on incoming material	Paperwork per order, plus a way to keep mill certificates tied to the lots they arrived with. Where the metal was melted has to be sorted before you quote, not after.	Your quality and purchasing people; we write the procedure.
6. Onboarding	The buyer's own supplier qualification. Applies: Before the first order: questionnaire, site visit, approved supplier list	To be established at discovery: which primes already have you on their supplier list	A capability and quality questionnaire, a day for a visit, and the buyer's own financial review. A loan approval is strong evidence, but it is not the buyer's test.	You, with the file prepared for you.

This is a map, not an assessment, and no certification or compliance is claimed here. Cybersecurity is the one gate where a third party has to sign in the end; the rest are record-keeping you can pass without an auditor.

How the map gets filled in

Every row above marked "to be established at discovery" is answered by a short discovery, not by guesswork. That is the whole of the first piece of work: an hour with you, the documents you already have, and a walk through where controlled data and controlled drawings actually live.

What we need from you

- Which customers you sell to today, and which of them ask about cybersecurity or export control.
- Whether any part you make or quote is on the munitions list, or comes with a drawing marked as export-controlled.
- Any certificates you hold — quality, export, or veteran-owned — with their scope and expiry.
- The last three purchase orders from a defence customer, so the clauses on them can be read.
- Who does your IT, and whether they would take on a documented scope.

What comes back

- This map, with every row filled in and the ones that do not apply struck out.
- The order to take them in, and what each one costs in money and in hours.
- Who owns each — you, your IT provider, a specialist, or us.

Fee. Fixed, agreed in writing before the work starts, and it is the same whether or not a loan is ever made. Ask for the number and it will be in the engagement letter.

This page is what the map looks like before the discovery. Once it is filled in, it carries the shop's own position instead.